

Pawar PUNCHED

The Congress watches in glee as the NCP chief is caught in yet another controversy. A weakened Pawar only adds to its clout both at the Centre and in Maharashtra.

By Priya Sahgal

Someone once said, "It is very difficult making predictions about the future". Sharad Pawar would agree. He says that he is no astrologer, but he doesn't need to read the stars to figure out that his relationship with the Congress is headed for yet another rocky patch. He only has to read last week's headlines. As Pawar squirms in embarrassment over a host of issues—be it his track record as agriculture minister or revelations about his family's involvement in bidding for IPL teams—his close aides say that it is the Congress that is out to scupper the grand Maratha's political future. Sometimes overtly, at others in covert operations. According to BCCI sources, the leak of various IPL documents embarrassing Pawar can be traced to a certain Congress Union minister's office.

Officially, the Congress has very carefully distanced itself from all controversies surrounding Pawar, with spokesman Abhishek Singhvi stating that "in all fairness these questions should be put to Mr Pawar". Congress general secretary Janardhan Dwivedi too refrains from talking about the issues saying that "the alliances are with parties, not individuals". It is true that the Congress has no choice in determining the ministers that its allies send to the Cabinet, but in the case of Pawar, there is an interesting divide between the party and the Government. Unlike Sonia, whose mistrust of Pawar dates even

before May 1999 when he split the Congress protesting against her prime ministerial candidature, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh regards Pawar as a valuable ally. Whether it is his favourite Nuclear Liability Bill or placating other allies on economic reforms, he knows he has Pawar's support. Unlike Congress cabinet ministers who often override the PMO

and go to 10 Janpath, Pawar has always given Manmohan his due.

The Maratha leader is no stranger to controversy. After denying that his family had no role in the IPL biddings, it has now emerged that Pawar, his wife Pratibha and daughter Supriya Sule (Lok Sabha MP from Baramati), hold a 16 per cent stake in City Corporation, a company that made a



SONIA'S DISTRUST OF PAWAR DATES BACK TO 1999 WHEN HE QUIT THE CONGRESS